

Lab 2.1: Create a Research Brief and Qualification Score

Introduction

In this lab, you will practice turning public information into sales judgments. Strong prospecting is not about collecting facts; it is about interpreting signals, identifying stakeholders, and deciding whether an opportunity deserves continued investment.

This exercise helps you move from surface-level research to structured qualification. You will research a target company, compile a brief on key facts and stakeholders, then evaluate the opportunity using BANT or TIMD frameworks.

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lab, you will be able to:

- Research target companies using publicly available information.
- Identify business signals indicating potential opportunities.
- Map stakeholders involved in purchasing decisions.
- Apply qualification frameworks to evaluate opportunities.
- Assess opportunity viability using available evidence.



Scenario

Company Name: ProClean Commercial Services

Industry: Commercial office cleaning and janitorial services

Target Signals to Research:

Office expansions or relocations

Employee growth or hiring spikes

Facility management changes

Increased workplace health or compliance focus

New office openings or consolidations

Your goal is to identify a company showing one or more of these signals and evaluate whether they represent a qualified opportunity for ProClean Commercial Services.

Tool Overview

Downloadable Resource: Qualification Scorecard Template

This is the required scoring instrument for this lab. You will use it in Step 3 to rate the opportunity across each qualification category and record the evidence behind each rating.

Downloadable Resource: Qualification Scorecard: How to Use This Tool

Read this companion guide before scoring. It explains each category, provides guiding questions and scoring guidance, and shows how to interpret your results when deciding whether to advance, pause, or deprioritize an opportunity.

Downloadable Resource: Lab 2.1 Exemplar Solution

Use this as a reference for structure and approach, not as a template to copy. Your submission should reflect your own research and reasoning.

Activity Steps

Exercise 1: Research and Qualify a Target Company

Step 1: Select a Target Company

Choose a real or hypothetical company that fits ProClean's ideal customer profile (office-based, 20-200 employees, showing growth signals). You may use:

- LinkedIn company pages (look for hiring activity, new locations)
- Company websites (check About, News, or Careers sections)
- Press releases or business news
- Job postings (indicate expansion or operational changes)

Step 2: Compile a Research Brief

Gather information on the following:

Company overview: industry, size, and location(s)

Recent business signals: Growth indicators, expansion, hiring, relocations

Key stakeholders: Roles likely involved in facility or vendor decisions (Office Manager, Operations Director, and similar roles)

Initial hypothesis: Why might this company need commercial cleaning services now?

Keep your brief concise and factual. Focus on relevance, not exhaustive detail.

Step 3: Apply Qualification Framework

Using the Qualification Scorecard Template, evaluate this opportunity using BANT or TIMD (or a blend of both). For each category:

- Assign a score: Low, Medium, or High

- Provide a short justification based on your research

- Identify key gaps that would require further discovery

You are not expected to have perfect information. You are expected to reason clearly with what is available.

Step 4: Make a Summary Judgment

Based on your qualification score, decide:

Is this opportunity worth pursuing?

What are the biggest unknowns?

What would you need to learn next?

Success Criteria

A strong submission will:

- Identify a company that matches ProClean's ideal customer profile.
- Include specific business signals (not generic assumptions).
- Map 2-3 key stakeholder roles (with role clarity, not just names).
- Apply qualification frameworks consistently with clear justifications.
- Acknowledge gaps or unknowns rather than making unsupported assumptions.

Demonstrate clear reasoning about whether the opportunity deserves continued pursuit.

Self-Assessment Checklist

By the end of this lab, you should have:

A one-page research brief including company overview, signals, stakeholders, and initial hypothesis.

A qualification score for each relevant category (BANT or TIMD).

Short justifications for each score based on research evidence.

A summary judgment about whether to pursue this opportunity.

Clear identification of gaps requiring further discovery.

Summary

Congratulations! You have completed this lab. In this activity, you researched a target company, identified relevant business signals, mapped key stakeholders, and applied qualification frameworks to evaluate opportunity potential. You also practiced making informed qualification decisions, recognizing information gaps, and determining appropriate next steps. These skills help sales professionals prioritize opportunities, focus prospecting efforts, and engage potential customers with greater relevance and confidence.